

During my anorexia I knew I would not die unless I starved for many days so I questioned why I felt so hungry. I realised I could prevent my suffering by switching my attention to my studies. Through this observation I learnt that the purpose of the mind was not to seek truth, but rather to bring about behaviour. It no longer became my highest point of inquiry and I began to see my mind as separate from myself.

Under intense starvation, my physiology was altered and I became highly sensitive towards thoughts and outer sensory input. I experienced intense emotional reactions and in response I exerted a lot of effort to constantly monitor my thoughts and sensory input. I worked backwards and primarily attempted to control my attention rather than my behaviour. I isolated myself and minimised uncontrolled sensory information. I often observed how my mind under illness would decide on a goal and cut out everything at the expense of that goal. A few hours later I no longer cared for the goal. I did not have any values or consistent purpose and began to feel as though I was multiple different people depending on the time of day.

During my time in hospital my friend gave me a book about Buddhism. I learnt that Buddhists had an explanation for the observations I had made of my mind. Buddhism suggests that the mind is a stream of impermanent mental events that directs or attaches itself to a different goal at any moment in time rather than having an essential self. Interestingly many modern theories of the mind, such as the theory of constructed emotion have adopted this very same view. In my own words through a neuroscience lens, as separate neural pathways are activated our purpose changes as we carry out the different tasks of our day. With the belief in a permanent self, we often search for one purpose to give our lives a sense of meaning. My purpose always falls in the context of conditions. Is there a self that responds to conditions or do the conditions create the self?

The world is filled with a lot of sensory information. How do we decide what we pay attention to? The mind is a sixth sense organ in Buddhist theory and thoughts are another form of sensory information. I pursued the Buddhist practice of meditation and attended a 10 day vipassana meditation retreat consisting of 10 hours of meditation a day. It was held in silence so outer sensory input was cut out and I primarily spent my time studying the sensory input of my mind that no one else had access to. I continued this pursuit and spent a month at a temple in South Korea studying how Buddhists approach the sensory world.

When I meditate, I find I am able to deconstruct cause and effect within the mind. Meditation has taught me that although the reality I perceive is never objective, there is no objective reality to be found in the first place. Reality is simply a feeling within me as I cannot ever attend to all of the external world at once. This prevents the concept of objectivity, and if something cannot be perceived, can it be real? Our perception of reality is a construct dependant on where our attention lies. I am interested in how attending to Buddhist practice changes perception of what is real both permanently and during meditative states.

Feeling causes believing. How do we decide what is constructed and what is real? We observe patterns over time. Stable patterns cause us to create concepts when two events are correlated and this is reflected within neuroscience. Concepts are stable patterns of neural activity formed through repeated experience. Physicist Carlo Rovelli explains that we perceive time having a direction due to this fact that our nervous system is structured in a way that causes us to see cause and effect. I found it intriguing to hear a physicist talk about time as product of the structure of the mind rather than a structure of physics.

Rovelli postulates that this perceived cause and effect also creates a sense of self. I find the link between self and time interesting. The concept of self exists due to us observing patterns that repeat themselves over and over again and again. In Rovelli's words, concepts are "induced by recurring structures of the sensorial input and of the successive elaborations". If repeated stable patterns allow us to conceptualise then conceptualising is possible due to the perception of directional time. The concept of self exists due to us observing stable patterns. Does this mean the perception of self can only exist with perception of directional time? What is the relationship between time and self? If time is a concept created by the mind, could meditation be used as a tool to understand this too? Time appears not only in phenomenology, it is rooted in biology in biological rhythms. Biological rhythms are subject to the laws of physics and change at different speeds and distances. How would these changes affect a psychological experience of time?

Before entering university, I researched and contacted numerous researchers at the university of Sussex, home to the centre for consciousness science. I was given a few different opportunities and chose to help a PhD student on his study on how subliminal communication can affect our perception. The aim of the study was to assess whether interpretation bias could be modified outside of conscious awareness using a subliminal training paradigm. The study acknowledged and supported my belief that each tiny moment of sensory information holds great power in affecting your perception of reality.

I am interested in gaining an understanding of the human mind rather than an understanding of myself. I am most interested understanding the commonalities we share that derive from ancient brain structures we all share. Psychology explores the differences we share, neuroscience explores how we are the same. We are all mostly the same.